

Heuristic Evaluation Report

Part I: Your Name

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Part II: Project Description

Draw Companion is a mobile application designed to help beginner artists and hobbyists overcome emotional barriers in learning to draw. The app focuses on three core functions/tasks: uploading drawings, finding inspiration, and tracking progress. It provides AI-driven feedback and a private space for users to reflect on their artistic growth.

Part III: Evaluation Execution

The evaluation was conducted during a lab session on 18/11/2025. I met with the MODY AI group members who provided their mobile phone paper prototype. One member acted as the facilitator explaining the project context and tasks, while another acted as the "phone" (iPhone?) manipulating the prototype elements.

I received three tasks to evaluate:

- **Simple Task:** Upload a drawing
- **Moderate Task:** Find inspiration for a new drawing
- **Complex Task:** Revisit older drawings of the same type to notice progress and stay motivated

I went through each task flow systematically, keeping Nielsen's 10 Heuristics in front of me, and recorded violations as I encountered them.

Part IV: List of Violations

1. H2: Match between system and the real world

Where: Photo Upload Flow, after capturing/selecting a photo from gallery.

What: The confirmation button is labeled "Use".

Why: "Use" is ambiguous in this context. Users typically expect terms like "Confirm", "Select", or "Upload" when adding a photo. The word "Use" does not clearly communicate that the action will proceed to the upload form.

Severity: 2

2. H8: Aesthetic and minimalist design

Where: Upload Drawing screen.

What: There is both a back button (top-left) and a "Cancel" button (bottom-left).

Why: Both elements serve the same function of abandoning the current operation. This redundancy adds unnecessary visual clutter and may confuse users about which one to use.

Severity: 1

3. H7: Flexibility and efficiency of use

Where: Upload Drawing screen and Progress category selection screen.

What: Users can only select from predefined categories (Nature, Modern, Abstract, Portraits and maybe more). There is no option to create custom categories.

Why: Predefined categories cannot cover all possible drawing types. Users who draw subjects outside these categories (e.g., anime, architecture) have no appropriate way to classify their work, reducing the app's usability.

Severity: 2

4. H1: Visibility of system status

Where: Progress category selection screen.

What: The category selection uses checkboxes, but it is unclear whether this is single-select or multi-select.

Why: Users cannot determine the expected selection behavior. Without clear indication (e.g., radio buttons for single-select, checkboxes with "select multiple" hint), users may select incorrectly or feel uncertain about their choices.

Severity: 2

5. H1: Visibility of system status

Where: Upload Drawing screen (Name, Description, Category, Date fields).

What: There is no indication of which fields are required and which are optional.

Why: Users cannot determine the minimum information needed to complete the upload. This may lead to failed submissions or unnecessary effort filling optional fields.

Severity: 2

6. H7: Flexibility and efficiency of use

Where: Progress screen, drawing list view.

What: The only way to find drawings is by filtering categories. There is no search function by image name or date.

Why: As users accumulate more drawings, locating a specific one becomes increasingly difficult. A search bar would significantly improve efficiency for users with large collections.

Severity: 3

7. H3: User control and freedom

Where: Progress screen, feedback prompt dialog.

What: The dialog asks "Do you want to receive feedback on the progress?" but only provides a "Yes" button. There is no "No" button to decline.

Why: Users who do not want feedback at that moment have no clear way to dismiss the prompt. This forces users into an unwanted action and removes their freedom of choice.

Severity: 3

8. H6: Recognition rather than recall

Where: Progress screen, drawing thumbnail grid.

What: The drawing thumbnails only show images and dates. There is no display of other metadata such as name, category, or description.

Why: Users must click into each drawing to recall its details. Displaying key metadata (at least the name) on the thumbnail would help users recognize and locate drawings without relying on memory.

Severity: 2

9. H3: User control and freedom

Where: Navigation throughout the app, particularly in the Progress flow.

What: The back navigation logic is inconsistent and unclear.

Why: Users may not understand where the back button will take them, especially after multiple navigation steps. This creates uncertainty and may cause users to feel "lost" in the app.

Severity: 3

10. H7: Flexibility and efficiency of use

Where: Progress screen, drawing detail view with carousel.

What: The image carousel always starts from the first drawing, regardless of which thumbnail the user tapped.

Why: When users select a specific drawing from the grid, they expect to see that drawing immediately. Having to swipe through from the beginning is inefficient and frustrating, especially with many drawings.

Severity: 2

Part V: Summary and Recommendations

Heuristic	# Violations
H1: Visibility of system status	2
H2: Match between system and the real world	1
H3: User control and freedom	2
H4: Consistency and standards	0
H5: Error prevention	0
H6: Recognition rather than recall	1
H7: Flexibility and efficiency of use	3
H8: Aesthetic and minimalist design	1
H9: Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors	0
H10: Help and documentation	0
HN: Non-heuristic issue	0

General Impressions

Draw Companion presents a thoughtful solution for beginner artists, with a clean visual design and a friendly mascot character that aligns well with the emotional support goal. The three-task structure (upload, inspiration, progress) addresses the core user needs identified in their research.

However, the evaluation revealed a notable pattern of **H7 (Flexibility and efficiency of use)** violations, suggesting the prototype prioritizes simplicity at the expense of power-user features. Additionally, multiple **H3 (User control and freedom)** issues indicate that users may feel constrained when navigating or making choices.

Recommendations

1. Change "Use" to "Confirm" or "Select" in the photo selection flow to match user expectations.
2. Allow users to create and manage their own categories. This is essential for an art app where subjects are highly diverse.
3. Mark required fields with an asterisk (*) or use placeholder text like "Required" to indicate mandatory inputs.
4. Implement a search bar in the Progress section that allows searching by drawing name, date, or category.
5. Add a "No" or "Maybe Later" button to the feedback prompt, respecting user autonomy.

6. Display at least the drawing name below each thumbnail in the Progress grid view.
7. Consider adding a context menu or long-press action on drawings in the Progress view that offers "Get Inspiration" for similar drawings. This would create a more seamless connection between reviewing past work and finding new ideas, matching the natural workflow described in the storyboard.
8. When users tap a specific drawing in the grid, the detail view should open directly to that drawing rather than starting from the first item.